

Exercise 5: Research strategies: *Researching virtual teamworking*

Read the short case study below and:

1. Consider the different research methodologies that are being considered and identify the strengths and weaknesses of each. Which methodology would you use? Or would you adapt one of them? Or use a hybrid of them both?
2. Set out the advantages and limitations of the methodology you have chosen

You are planning your MBA dissertation. The large financial organisation for which you work adopted virtual teamworking very quickly during the first phase of the Covid-19 pandemic in 2020. Almost all the employees were asked to work from home, and equipment and software were provided to enable them to access the company networks and databases, and so they could interact electronically with each other, using emails and Microsoft Teams. The Teams software was used by staff to create forums and post information, and also carry out video calls and meetings.

As the pandemic eased in 2021, there were some moves by the organisation to get people back into their offices, but some staff wanted to continue to work from home for at least some of the time. Management accepted this and the organisation began to move to a hybrid form of working, with some attendance in offices and some working from home, and therefore some continuation of virtual teamworking.

You are a team leader, and you are aware that teamworking and team leading are somewhat different when communication is by electronic means, as compared with meetings in person. You have the impression that the company managed virtual teamworking reasonably well during the pandemic – with some teams and some team leaders doing better than others. But this is just your impression, and you would like to do some systematic research into this for your MBA dissertation.

You decide that your research question will be:

What were the strengths and weaknesses of the use of virtual teamworking by the Big Bank company during the Covid-19 pandemic in 2020-2021, and what good practices can be continued in the future?

Your draft research objectives are:

1. A critical review of literature on virtual team working, including the leadership of virtual teams
2. Gather information from team members and team leaders on their experiences of virtual teamworking in 2020-2021
3. Analyse this field research information with reference to relevant published theories
4. Recommend actions to be taken in the future for any continuation of virtual teamworking in Big Bank company

So far, you have considered two alternative research methodologies:

Semi-structured interviews with a small number of team members and team leaders about their experiences. You think you might interview 12 people – six team leaders and six team members. The team leaders would be able to talk about their leadership of their team, and also about their experiences of being a member of more senior teams.

Questionnaires distributed to a large number of team members and team leaders. You think you could distribute over 300 questionnaires to team members and team leaders.